

Letter from the Executive Board

Dear Delegates,

In the intricate web of diplomacy and power that spans our fractured world, this closing week of January 1992 holds a distinct, albeit often overlooked, place. As we convene this session of the United Nations Security Council, we are not merely participants in a simulation; we are stepping into the shoes of heads of state and government in an era marked by a paramount transformation; an order upended by the collapse of one superpower, the disappearance of a decades-old ideological fault line, and the uncertain shape of what comes next.

The post-Cold War world, a landscape still settling from tremors few predicted and fewer still know how to navigate, has for the better part of the last half-century been defined by the rigid architecture of bipolar rivalry. Marred by proxy conflict, nuclear brinkmanship, and paralysis within this very chamber for the better part of the last forty-five years, the recent dissolution of the Soviet Union in December 1991 was not a mere administrative footnote; it was a rupture that threatened , and still threatens, to leave a vacuum the world does not yet know how to fill.

As esteemed members of this UNSC, your responsibility is to navigate this tumultuous period with a deep understanding of not only how the UNSC can take action but also your contributions as a diplomat that can bring change. As you step into this role, we urge you to embrace it with the gravity it warrants, for the lessons we learn from the shadows of history are lanterns illuminating our path forward.

Please note that this Background Guide is designed to give you a clear insight into the agenda. A thorough understanding of a conflict and its roots is always the first step in solving it. However, this document is in no way exhaustive and is only meant to establish a platform for beginning your research. The Executive Board recommends that Delegates have sufficient knowledge of the proceedings in their allotted country concerning its foreign affairs.

Be aware of your country's stance on the particular agenda, as it will be crucial when you prepare your arguments. In case of any questions, procedural or otherwise, please feel free to direct them to any member of the Executive Board, and we will get back to you as soon as possible. For this particular edition of the UNSC, the Committee will be following the UNA-USA Rules of Procedure. Finally, the Executive Board would like to wish all Delegates the best in their preparation for the conference and hope for two productive days of deliberation.

With sincerest regards,

Kumara Shivanand, Chairperson, UNSC

Advay Gandham, Vice-Chairperson, UNSC

Mahesh Varma, Rapporteur, UNSC

About the Committee

Brief Overview:

The United Nations Security Council (UNSC) is one of the six principal organs of the United Nations as outlined in Chapter 3 Article 7 of the Charter of the United Nations and is tasked mainly with the responsibility to maintain international peace. After an amendment to the Charter in 1965, the structure of the UNSC has remained as follows: Five Permanent Members (People's Republic of China, Republic of France, Russian Federation, United Kingdom of Great Britain and Northern Ireland and the United States of America) and Ten Non-Permanent Members. The Five Permanent Members (also known as P5) were the victorious powers of the Second World War and were assigned this important role considering their role in the world order at the time. The ten non-permanent members are elected by the United Nations General Assembly for two-year terms. The presidency of the UNSC rotates among its members monthly, in English alphabetical order of the countries' names. The president is responsible for setting the agenda, presiding over meetings, and overseeing the work of the Security Council. This rotating presidency ensures that all members of the UNSC, whether permanent or non-permanent, have the opportunity to influence the Council's work. The P5 have privileges in addition to their permanent seat in the Council, the most popularly known one being the Veto Power. Though the word 'Veto' is not explicitly mentioned in the Charter, to explain it simply, each of the P5 members can ensure a substantive resolution does not pass solely due to their single negative vote in the Council, irrespective of the other's votes or a majority as such.

Mandate:

By the UN Charter, the UNSC is mandated to foster friendly relations among all the members of the UN and make sure there is cooperation and harmony among nations when they take action to solve international problems. By Article 25 of the charter, all member states agree to comply with the resolutions passed by the UNSC. For any conflict that is brought before the UNSC, it initially strives to give a peaceful solution. It sets forth the principles for such an agreement, undertakes investigation and mediation if necessary and also dispatches missions or appoints special envoys. It can also ask the UN Secretary General to achieve a peaceful settlement of the conflict. If a dispute already has a hostile nature, the Council does everything in its power to end it such as issuing ceasefire directives and dispatching military forces (or) peacekeeping missions to achieve a peaceful settlement. If this also proves to be unhelpful, the UNSC can enforce economic sanctions, arms embargoes, financial penalties and restrictions, and travel bans. It can sever diplomatic relations and also enforce blockades or collective military operations. If armed force application is necessary, the SC plans for its application with the help of a Military Staff committee. The SC is also mandated to send in a yearly report and, when necessary, special reports to the United Nations General Assembly.

It is also responsible for formulating plans to regulate armaments with the help of the Military Staff Committee.

The SC can also establish subsidiary organs as and when they deem it is necessary for the performance of its functions. In addition to these powers, the UNSC also has a role in other aspects of the UN system. It recommends to the General Assembly the admission of new members to the United Nations and the approval of any changes to the UN Charter. It also plays a key role in the appointment of the Secretary-General, the UN's chief administrative officer.

About the Agenda

Agenda - UNSC Summit Meeting Freeze Date: 30th January 1992

The world entered a turning point in international peace and security in the opening weeks of 1992. Five weeks earlier, on 26 December 1991, the Union of Soviet Socialist Republics had formally ceased to exist, completing the end of a rivalry with the United States of America that had structured world politics for more than four decades. The consequences reached the Security Council directly: on 24 December 1991, President Boris Yeltsin had informed the Secretary-General that the Russian Federation would continue the USSR's membership in the United Nations, including its permanent seat on the Council, with the support of the member states of the Commonwealth of Independent States. This succession was always a legally conflicted one as it was accomplished without amendment to the Charter or a vote of the general membership.

I. The 3046th Security Council Summit Meeting

The prevailing mood among the Council's members was not apprehension but expectation: the ideological deadlock that had constrained the body since 1946 had lifted, and many believed the Council could at last operate as its founders intended. Recognising both the opportunity and the uncertainty of the moment, the Security Council convened its 3046th meeting on 31 January 1992, the first ever held at the level of Heads of State and Government rather than permanent representatives, under the agenda item "The Responsibility of the Security Council in the Maintenance of International Peace and Security". Thirteen Heads of State and Government attended, alongside two Foreign Ministers. Its purpose was to consider how the Council should respond to a transformed security environment and what larger role it might assume within it. To understand the challenges facing that meeting, the political landscape of the preceding decades must first be examined; a landscape shaped by the Cold War and by the dissolution of the Soviet Union that brought it to a close.

II. The Cold War

The Cold War was less a single conflict than a structural condition of international politics between 1945 and 1991. Its immediate cause was mutual insecurity over Europe: Britain and

the United States, alarmed by Soviet domination of Eastern Europe, feared the further spread of communist power westward, while the Soviet Union was determined to retain that belt in part as protection against a revived German threat. Both positions were defensible to those who held them, and history assigns sole responsibility to neither. The American response took shape as containment, articulated in George Kennan's Long Telegram and formalised when Truman told Congress in 1947 that the United States must support peoples resisting subjugation from outside, a principle that governed American policy for four decades. Many historians deem the Truman Doctrine to mark the official beginning of the decades long Cold War. The rivalry reached its first peak in 1948–53, encompassing the Berlin blockade and airlift, the creation of NATO, the communist victory in the Chinese civil war and the Korean War; the admission of a remilitarised West Germany to NATO in 1955 produced the Warsaw Pact in reply. The Soviet atomic test of 1949 and the American move to thermonuclear weapons opened an arms race that peaked again in 1958–62 around the Cuban missile crisis. For the Security Council, this rivalry meant paralysis rather than mere tension. The Charter had presumed continued great-power cooperation; the veto instead rendered enforcement action against any permanent member or its clients effectively impossible, and it was cast over two hundred times between 1946 and 1990. The Council authorised force in Korea in 1950 only because the Soviet delegation was then boycotting the chamber over the seating of China. The General Assembly's Uniting for Peace resolution of November 1950, and the invention of peacekeeping at Suez in 1956 were both improvisations around a Council that could not function as designed.

III. Global Realignment

The conflict's geography meanwhile shifted away from Europe. Decolonisation produced dozens of new states unwilling to be enrolled by either bloc, and the Bandung Conference of 1955 and the founding of the Non-Aligned Movement at Belgrade in 1961 asserted a third position that shaped General Assembly majorities for the remainder of the period. Proxy warfare emerged across the globe in Cuba, and in Vietnam, where a limited intervention became a decade-long war, and later in Angola, the Horn of Africa and Afghanistan. Nixon sought to replace a bipolar world with a multipolar one, opening relations with Beijing and signing SALT I with Brezhnev in 1972; the Helsinki Final Act of 1975 added human-rights commitments that dissidents within the Eastern bloc would later invoke against their own governments. Détente gave way to renewed hostility after the Soviet intervention in Afghanistan in December 1979 and under Reagan, who allegedly financed anticommunist governments and insurgencies across the developing world. The decisive pressures, however, proved internal. Facing severe economic difficulty and mounting political ferment, Gorbachev took office in 1985 and introduced glasnost and perestroika, reforms intended to preserve the Soviet system that instead withdrew the coercion holding its periphery in place. Communist governments across Eastern Europe were replaced during 1989, and the Berlin Wall opened in November. The UNSC registered the change at once: the near-unanimity behind Resolution 678 on Kuwait in November 1990 would have been unattainable at any earlier point. Yet the division of Europe ended well before the Soviet state did.

Dissolution Of USSR: A Timeline of the most important events

1985

Mikhail Gorbachev was elected as the General Secretary of the Communist Party of the Soviet Union (CPSU).

1986

February 26th: The terms Glasnost meaning 'openness' and Perestroika meaning 'restructuring' were used by Gorbachev in a speech to the Communist Party congress and urged more policies in the USSR aligning with these ideologies.

April 26th: The Chernobyl Disaster occurred near the city of Pripyat in the north of the Ukrainian SSR.

1987

June 14th: Peaceful demonstrations began in Baltic states opposing Stalin's mass deportation in the 1940s.

December 8th: The Intermediate Range Nuclear Forces Treaty was signed by US President Ronald Reagan and Soviet General Secretary Mikhail Gorbachev.

1988

April: Edgar Savisaar, called for a legal and democratic opposition to the ruling communists on a live TV show which resulted in the founding of The Estonian Popular Front. June: The Sajudis (Lithuanian Reform Movement) and Latvian Popular are founded.

July 1st: Gorbachev won the backing of delegates at the 19th Conference of the CPSU to create a new legislative body called the Congress of People's Deputies.

29th November: The Soviet Union allowed its citizens to have unrestricted access to foreign news sources.

1989

March 26th: First elections to the Congress of People's Deputies were held. Voter participation was above 85%.

May 29th: Boris Yeltsin was elected to a seat on the Supreme Soviet of the Soviet Union and forms the first opposition, the Inter Regional Deputies Group, consisting of Russian Nationalists and liberals.

June 4th: An Anti-Soviet Party, Solidarity won 99 out of 100 seats in the Polish Senate.

October 25th: The Supreme Soviet votes to eliminate special seats for the CPSU and other official organisations in Union level and Republic level elections. It also passed measures that would allow direct elections for Presidents of each of the 15 constituent Republics.

October 27th: The Russian SFSR's constitution is amended resulting in the formation of a

Congress of People's Deputies.

November 4th: Half a million East Germans took to the streets of East Berlin to protest for the demolition of the Berlin Wall.

November 9th: The travel ban between East Berlin and West Berlin was lifted and the Berlin Wall was demolished.

1990

February: Multi-Party Elections were held for the first time in the history of the USSR, leading to the CPSU losing in both Lithuanian and Moldavian SSR's.

March 4th: The Russian SFSR elected Boris Yeltsin to the Congress of People's Deputies of Russia.

March 11th: The 'Act of the Re-Establishment of the State of Lithuania' was proclaimed by the newly elected Lithuanian parliament.

March 18th: CPSU lost the elections in both Estonian and Latvian SSR.

May 20th: CPSU lost the election in the Armenian SSR.

May 29th: Boris Yeltsin was elected to be the President of the Russian SFSR.

June 12th: The Russian SFSR declared sovereignty through a political act by the Congress of People's Deputies.

July 12th: Boris Yeltsin resigned from the CPSU.

July 27th: The Supreme Soviet of the Byelorussian SSR passed a Declaration of State Sovereignty, asserting its sovereignty as a republic inside the Soviet Union.

August 23rd: The Supreme Soviet of the Armenian SSR adopted the Declaration of Independence of Armenia.

October 28th: CPSU lost the election in the Georgian SSR.

November 23rd: A draft of the New Union Treaty was submitted to the Supreme Soviet of the Soviet Union

Conflict In Yugoslavia

I. Background & Demographics

In the 1990s, the Socialist Federal Republic of Yugoslavia was one of the largest, most developed and diverse countries in the Balkans. It was a non-aligned federation of six republics: Bosnia and Herzegovina, Croatia, Macedonia, Montenegro, Serbia and Slovenia. In addition to the six republics, the two separate regions of Kosovo and Vojvodina held the status of autonomous provinces within the Republic of Serbia. Yugoslavia was a mix of ethnic groups and religions, with Orthodox Christianity, Catholicism and Islam being the main religions. With the collapse of communism and resurgent nationalism in Eastern Europe during the early 1990s, Yugoslavia experienced a period of intense political and economic crisis. The central government weakened while militant nationalism grew apace. There was a proliferation of political parties who advocated the outright independence of republics while simultaneously urging greater powers for certain republics within the federation.

II. Political Movements & Nationalism

Political leaders used nationalist rhetoric to erode a common Yugoslav identity and fuel fear and mistrust among different ethnic groups. By 1991, the break-up of the country loomed with Slovenia and Croatia blaming Serbia for unjustly dominating Yugoslavia's government, military and finances. Serbia in turn accused the two republics of separatism. The first of the six republics to formally leave Yugoslavia was Slovenia, declaring independence on 25 June 1991. This triggered an intervention of the Yugoslav People's Army (JNA) which turned into a brief military conflict, generally referred to as the Ten-Day War. It ended in a victory for the Slovenian forces, with the JNA withdrawing its soldiers and equipment.

III. Slovenian & Croatian Uprisings

Croatia declared independence on the same day as Slovenia. The sizable ethnic Serb minority in Croatia openly rejected the authority of the newly proclaimed Croatian state citing the right to remain within Yugoslavia. With the help of the JNA and Serbia, Croatian Serbs rebelled, declaring nearly a third of Croatia's territory under their control to be an independent Serb state. Croats and other non-Serbs were expelled from its territory in a violent campaign of ethnic cleansing. Heavy fighting in the second half of 1991 witnessed the shelling of the ancient city of Dubrovnik, and the siege and destruction of Vukovar by Serb forces.

Those two sieges produced the heaviest fighting in Europe since 1945. Vukovar fell on 18 November after shelling that left the city in ruins; in the days that followed, some two hundred people removed from the Vukovar hospital were killed at Ovčara. The bombardment of Dubrovnik, a UNESCO World Heritage site under no meaningful military threat, continued into December, and the shelling of its Old Town on 6 December drew particular international condemnation. On 19 December the Croatian Serb leadership renamed its entity the Republic of Serbian Krajina. By the end of the year the war had killed thousands and displaced several hundred thousand civilians.

IV. Ceasefire Negotiations & The Vance Plan

In November, Cyrus Vance, the Secretary-General's Personal Envoy, secured agreement at Geneva from Serbian President Slobodan Milošević, Croatian President Franjo Tuđman and Yugoslav defence minister Veljko Kadijević on a plan providing for a ceasefire, the withdrawal of JNA forces from Croatia and the deployment of UN peacekeepers to designated protected areas. That ceasefire did not hold, and further negotiation produced an

implementation agreement signed at Sarajevo on 2 January 1992 by JNA Lieutenant General Andrija Rašeta and Croatian defence minister Gojko Šušak. It was the fifteenth ceasefire in six months and entered into force the following day. Its durability remained untested at the date of this summit.

V. Diplomatic Responses

The diplomatic response ran along two tracks, neither of which had resolved the fundamental question of Yugoslavia's legal status. The European Community convened a peace conference at The Hague from September 1991 under Lord Carrington, and established an arbitration commission chaired by Robert Badinter to advise on the legal questions arising. In Opinion No. 1 of 29 November 1991, the commission held that Yugoslavia was not a continuing state suffering secession but a federation in the process of dissolution. This implied that republics were successor states with claims to recognition rather than rebel provinces. The EC adopted recognition guidelines on 16 December; Germany announced its recognition of Slovenia and Croatia on 23 December, ahead of its partners, and EC recognition followed on 15 January 1992. Macedonia, which had declared independence in the autumn of 1991 and separated peacefully, was denied comparable recognition owing to Greek objections to its name. In Kosovo, where Serbia had revoked provincial autonomy in 1989, the Albanian population had held an unofficial referendum in September 1991 and declared a republic that no state recognised.

VI. Security Council Engagements

For the Security Council, the record as of 30 January 1992 was one of cautious and incremental engagement. Beyond the arms embargo imposed under Chapter VII by Resolution 713 and extended by Resolution 727, the Council had endorsed Vance's mission in Resolution 721 of 27 November 1991 while stating that a peacekeeping operation could not be deployed until a ceasefire was genuinely observed, and in Resolution 724 of 15 December had accepted the Secretary-General's assessment that those conditions were not yet met, authorising only a small group of military liaison officers and a committee to monitor the embargo. Bosnia had applied for EC recognition on 20 December 1991; the Community deferred a decision pending a referendum on independence. On 9 January the Bosnian Serb assembly had proclaimed its own republic within Bosnia. Whether the Council could act before that situation resolved itself by force was among the open questions facing the Heads of State and Government convening in New York.

UNSC Intervention in International Conflicts

I. The Charter Framework

The Council's powers of intervention are drawn from three chapters. **Chapter VI** (Articles 33–38) permits it to recommend procedures or terms for the settlement of disputes likely to endanger international peace; action under this chapter is non-binding and directed at mediation, arbitration and judicial settlement. **Chapter VII** (Articles 39–51) permits binding decisions on all Member States. Article 39 empowers the Council to determine the existence of a threat to the peace, breach of the peace, or act of aggression; Article 41 provides for measures short of force, including economic and trade restrictions, severance of diplomatic relations and arms embargoes; Article 42 authorises action by air, sea or land forces where Article 41 measures would be or have proved inadequate. **Chapter VIII** (Articles 52–54) permits the Council to utilise regional arrangements for enforcement action under its authority.

One provision has never been used. Article 43 envisaged Member States concluding agreements to place armed forces permanently at the Council's disposal, directed by the Military Staff Committee. No such agreement has ever been concluded and the Committee has been dormant since the 1940s. Every enforcement action in the Council's history has therefore been subcontracted to a coalition operating under national command — a structural fact, not an accident of any particular crisis.

II. Case Studies

Korea, 1950

On 25 June 1950, North Korean forces crossed the 38th parallel. The Council adopted Resolution 82 the same day, determining the attack to be a breach of the peace and demanding a cessation of hostilities and withdrawal. It was able to do so only because the Soviet Union was then boycotting the Council in protest at the seating of the Republic of China rather than the People's Republic, the permanent member most likely to veto was absent from the chamber. Resolution 83 of 27 June recommended that Member States furnish South Korea with assistance to repel the attack, and Resolution 84 of 7 July established a unified command under the United States, authorising it to fly the UN flag alongside national colours.

The command arrangement set the template. Rather than implement Article 43, the Council delegated operational control, strategic direction and tactical command to Washington.

Sixteen Member States contributed combat troops and five provided medical units, but political control remained concentrated in the United States, which reported periodically to the Council. When Soviet Ambassador Yakov Malik returned in August 1950 to assume the rotating presidency, the window closed. To circumvent the resulting paralysis, the United States secured the adoption of General Assembly Resolution 377 A (V), "Uniting for Peace," on 3 November 1950: where a lack of unanimity among the permanent members prevents the Council from exercising its primary responsibility, the Assembly shall consider the matter immediately, and may convene an Emergency Special Session within twenty-four hours at the request of seven Council members or a majority of Member States. Though its resolutions are recommendations only, the Assembly asserted the authority to recommend collective measures including the use of armed force. (The Council threshold is now nine of fifteen, following the 1965 enlargement.)

The closure of that window was demonstrated within a month. Following the entry of Chinese People's Volunteer Army forces across the Yalu in late October, a draft resolution of 30 November 1950 sponsored by France, Cuba, Ecuador, Norway, the United Kingdom and the United States, affirming the inviolability of the Chinese-Korean frontier and seeking Chinese withdrawal, received nine votes and was vetoed by the Soviet Union. The matter moved to the Assembly, which on 1 February 1951 adopted Resolution 498 (V), finding that the Central People's Government had engaged in aggression in Korea, affirming continued United Nations action, and establishing a Good Offices Committee to pursue a ceasefire.

Precedent: Council enforcement proved possible only in the absence of a permanent member, and even then command was delegated rather than held. When the member returned, the Council reverted to deadlock and the initiative passed to the General Assembly.

Suez, 1956

On 26 July 1956, President Nasser nationalised the Universal Company of the Suez Maritime Canal to finance the Aswan High Dam after the withdrawal of Western funding, prompting Anglo-French protests over freedom of navigation. The dispute reached the Council in October. Resolution 118 of 13 October set out six requirements for any settlement: free and open transit without overt or covert discrimination; respect for Egyptian sovereignty; insulation of the Canal's operation from the politics of any country; tolls and charges fixed by agreement between Egypt and users; a fair proportion of dues allotted to development; and arbitration of unresolved matters between the Canal Company and Egypt. Those principles were adopted unanimously, but the second part of the resolution, dealing with how they would be implemented, was vetoed by the USSR.

Meanwhile, between 22 and 24 October, representatives of France, the United Kingdom and Israel met secretly at Sèvres. Israel attacked across Sinai on 29 October; the following day Britain and France issued a joint ultimatum demanding both belligerents withdraw ten miles

from the Canal; on Egypt's refusal, Anglo-French air strikes began on 31 October and amphibious landings at Port Said on 5 November. In the Council, a United States draft of 30 October demanding Israeli withdrawal and calling on all members to refrain from force commanded majority support and was vetoed by France and the United Kingdom; a subsequent Soviet draft was vetoed by the same two states. Two permanent members had used the veto to shield their own military operation.

The Council's escape was procedural. Resolution 119 of 31 October, adopted seven votes to two with UK and France opposing, invoked Uniting for Peace to convene the First Emergency Special Session. Since the nature of the resolution was procedural, no veto could be cast against it. The Assembly sat from 1 to 10 November. Working with Secretary-General Dag Hammarskjöld, Canadian External Affairs Minister Lester B. Pearson proposed an international force to supervise the cessation of hostilities. Resolution 997 (ES-I) of 2 November called for a ceasefire, withdrawal behind the armistice lines and reopening of the Canal; Resolution 1000 (ES-I) of 5 November established the United Nations Emergency Force under Major-General E.L.M. Burns of Canada; Resolution 1001 (ES-I) of 7 November approved the Secretary-General's plan for its composition and legal status.

UNEF I created the template for traditional peacekeeping, operating between Chapter VI mediation and Chapter VII enforcement on four principles: deployment required the consent of the territorial sovereign, so that Egypt admitted the force while Israel refused it on its side of the line; the force was strictly impartial and altered no legal claim or political position; personnel carried defensive arms only and could use force solely in self-defence; and permanent members were excluded from contributing combat troops, contingents being drawn instead from non-aligned middle powers including Canada, India, Sweden, Brazil, Colombia, Denmark, Finland, Indonesia, Norway and Yugoslavia. The force supervised Anglo-French withdrawal by 22 December 1956 and Israeli withdrawal from Sinai and Gaza by March 1957, then held a demilitarised buffer along the armistice line for a decade, until Egypt withdrew its consent in May 1967 and the force departed. War followed within three weeks.

Precedent: the Assembly can act where the Council cannot, and peacekeeping can be invented where the Charter provides for nothing. But a force that exists by consent can be dismissed by consent, and will be dismissed precisely when it is most needed.

Kuwait, 1990–91

Iraq invaded Kuwait on 2 August 1990. The Council adopted Resolution 660 the same day, determining a breach of the peace under Article 39 and demanding immediate and unconditional withdrawal; Resolution 661 of 6 August imposed comprehensive economic sanctions under Article 41. When these failed to produce withdrawal, Resolution 678 of 29 November 1990 authorised Member States cooperating with Kuwait to use "all necessary means" to uphold the Council's resolutions unless Iraq complied by 15 January 1991. It passed twelve votes to two, with China abstaining rather than exercising its veto and the

Soviet Union voting in favour. Coalition operations began on 17 January and ended with Iraqi withdrawal in late February.

What followed was more significant than the war. Resolution 687 of 3 April 1991 imposed on a defeated sovereign state a demarcated border, the destruction of its chemical, biological and long-range missile capabilities under international inspection by a newly created special commission, a compensation fund financed from its oil revenues, and continued sanctions pending compliance. Two days later, Resolution 688 addressed Iraqi repression of its own Kurdish population, treating the resulting refugee flows as a threat to international peace and security in the region. Resolution 689 established an observer mission on the demilitarised border.

Kuwait, however, is not evidence that the system had begun working as designed. Article 43 was again bypassed; the Council authorised force and then delegated its conduct entirely to a coalition it did not command, receiving reports rather than giving orders. What had changed was not the machinery but the politics. The USSR chose to cooperate rather than obstruct, and within a year had ceased to exist.

Precedent: with permanent-member agreement, the Council can authorise force and can bind a state's sovereignty far more deeply than at any prior point. Resolution 688 further suggests that internal repression may constitute a threat to international peace. Whether either precedent survives contact with a case where the permanent members disagree is untested.

III. The Council in January 1992

The record above spans forty-two years and contains two authorisations of force, each made possible by an anomaly in Soviet conduct rather than by the Charter operating as intended. Uniting for Peace, peacekeeping itself, the coalition command model, all of these were improvised around a Council that could not act the way it wanted. The twelve months preceding this summit saw increased activity from the preceding decade: observer missions on the Iraq–Kuwait border and in Western Sahara, a verification mission in El Salvador, an advance mission in Cambodia following the Paris Accords of 23 October 1991, and a peacekeeping plan for Croatia awaiting approval. Delegates should consider whether this reflects a Council finally able to discharge its Charter functions, or a Council rapidly accumulating commitments on the strength of a permanent-member consensus whose durability no one has yet tested.

